A CORPSE FOR EVERY RAILWAY SLEEPER TO POWER TRAINS!

To start with, people called the train a ‘lokhandi rakshas’ (‘iron demon’ in Marathi). They maintained that no native of a high caste would ever ‘defile himself by entering a railway carriage’. [44] Among the natives were also a handful of enterprising businessmen who knew the importance of the railways, its benefits and its profits. The few who were not superstitious or ambitious about the railways simply believed it was all a cruel joke. They said that the idea of a ‘steam-run machine pulling a row of wagons’ was just a ‘bluff’ to cheat poor Indians of their land and money. The rumours refused to go away. While some said it was a ploy by the English to collect all the money from India and run away, others questioned the project, asking whether the great saints and rishi munis were fools that they had not discovered such a thing earlier. Had steam-powered locomotion really been possible, it would have been put to use much earlier. As people saw ‘Lord Falkland’ in action every day, another rumour was circulated that one had to bury children and young couples under the rail sleepers to power the rail engine and that the British sepoys were looking for and catching hold of every young couple and child found on the streets to put under the tracks. Yet another rumour spread was that if one travelled by rail, one’s lifespan would decrease, as one would end up reaching the destination faster, fast-forwarding one’s life and age! [45]

But as things proceeded and the benefits of easy, clean and faster transport began to be observed, the rumours and objections died down. What had started as a means to primarily ferry cotton and goods soon became a lucrative passenger service. Edwardson’s account, written in 1868 with the aid of the Records of India Office, states :

> The steam engine was overturning prejudices, uprooting habits and changing customs. A man who, before railways existed, on no account would have walked or carried a pound weight, but must have had a palkhee and bearers, now cheerfully marches to the station with a carpet bag; and, strange to say, even unpunctuality and apathy vanish before the warning bell of a station master. Railways, which had gone far in England to annihilate distance, were in India to reduce to a manageable extent the vast distance of the continent; were to strengthen the government; to bind races together; and by giving an impetus to commerce, to vivify and give such a bias to the character of the peoples of India, as ages had not effected, and ages would not efface.

BIZARRE STORIES FROM THE EAST

As the first set of locomotives and carriages began working along the East India Railway in Howrah, there were equally bizarre stories and reports as in